The Sea Turtle Hospital

By Karen E. Bender

INTERCOM VOICE: Lockdown. School is currently in lockdown.

INTRODUCTION

Trapped . . . For many struggling families in America, the word "trapped" can literally describe every aspect of their lives. Trapped in a cycle of poverty, Trapped by health issues beyond their control. Trapped by drug addiction, by the color of their skin, trapped by the very society in which they live. And for many, this state is multi-generational.

In this selection, a struggling kindergarten teacher realizes that she and her students are very similar to the damaged sea turtles they visit at . . .

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The lockdown at Arthur Elementary was the second at the school this week. Mrs. Reeves told me to lock the door and draw the blinds while she got the better (safer?) job of herding the kids into the reading nook.

The school shut down, locking windows and doors, supposedly allowing no one in or out, when there were

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reports of violence in the neighborhood. The first lockdown of the week happened after a [student] at the nearby junior high stood up during algebra class, brought out a hammer, and started whacking his classmates. And today, there was the brisk, almost office-like pop of gunshots two blocks away. I had worked here for a year and a half, and the lockdown protocol still messed me up, the click of the lock, the brisk, absurd drawing of the blinds, as though the thin plastic provided any protection from anything.

The kindergartners crouched, knees to chest, in their uniforms, the blue pants and crisp white collar shirts. They were good at making themselves tiny, even the larger ones.

MISS SAMSON: *(trying to sound hopeful about the collective future)* Remember to get your permission slips signed for our exciting field trip to the sea turtle hospital next week!

Keisha climbed into my lap. We crouched there for ten minutes. Twenty. Thirty. [Then] there was the

sound of a woman's heels. My heart picked up. Principal Williams unlocked the door.

By four p.m., the traffic circle was empty and all the children were shipped off to their various hopes and catastrophes. The only one still here was Keisha Jones. She calmly chewed on one of her many dark brown braids.

MISS SAMSON: Who's picking you up today? Your mom? Your dad? Your aunt?

She raised her shoulders and dropped them. We walked back into the office where I called her home.

MISS SAMSON: This is Miss Samson, Keisha's teacher. She's still at school. We wondered who was coming to pick her up.

AUNT: Oh. Sorry, I guess it was supposed to be me—"

MISS SAMSON: Is her mother around?

AUNT: She's on second shift at the hospital.

MISS SAMSON: Is anyone else here who could pick her up?

AUNT: I sprained my foot, miss, and I can't walk.

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There were various heartbreaking excuses, relatives who were assigned pickup but had been arrested, the ones who had fallen asleep in front of the TV, broken down cars . . . but mostly the reason people missed school pickup were dreary—the assigned person was at work. Everyone was always at work. The first job, the second job, etc. and there was another kid sitting there, waiting.

MISS SAMSON: I'll drive her home.

Keisha jumped up and pumped her fist with joy, as though she'd won a raffle. [See] Keisha had decided I was good. I had done nothing but give her a little attention. We sat and sounded out words together. I see a c-at. The c-at is s-oft. She was the best one in class, my speed reader.

KEISHA: *(heavy sigh)* I don't want to go home yet . . .

I knew where she lived; it was a brick development that, with its white columns, broken glass on the sidewalk. Groups of men hanging out midday, cars with towels covering broken windows. Some of the kids who

lived there ate double breakfasts in the cafeteria because they hadn't eaten any dinner the night before.

KEISHA: I'm hungry. Really hungry.

MISS SAMSON: Do you want me to pick up some dinner? It'll just take a sec.

KEISHA: Sure! Yes!

I pulled into the first eatery I saw, and we piled out. The register worker, whose nametag said Shawnte, [was] a young woman with gold metallic eye shadow.

SHAWNTE: *(suspiciously)* Keisha! Who you with?

KEISHA: This is my teacher.

MISS SAMSON: I'm giving her a ride home.

KEISHA: My momma's working and my aunt hurt her foot, and everyone was working but my teacher took me home . . . .I want the junior thickburger with onion rings and a strawberry shake!

Keisha pulled one, two, three napkins out of the dispenser, spread them into a sort of tablecloth on the plastic table.

MISS SAMSON: How do you know Shawnte?

KEISHA: She dated my brother.

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SHAWNTE: Here we are.

Shawnte, set the burger in front of Keisha, who grabbed [it] and started wolfing it down.

SHAWNTE: How's your dad?

KEISHA: *(in between bites)* He went to a hotel. When he started talking really fast.

MISS SAMSON: *(gesturing for a private conversation)* What happened?

SHAWNTE: *(whispering)* Schizo or something. No insurance, no meds. Couple days ago, he broke the TV.

I looked at Keisha, finishing the onion rings, and I imagined. [Then] she sat on my lap while I read a book: Sea Turtles

MISS SAMSON: Turtles lay about 120 eggs in a nest. After hatchlings come out, they head to the sea. Only a lucky few survive.

The pictures showed the turtles swimming. They looked like people who had not quite become people, but were trying, floating, with their tiny almost-arms.

KEISHA: I want to see one. *(adamantly)* Now. Please! I want to see something new.

She looked at me, expectantly. The sea turtle hospital was about twenty minutes from here. I was a kindergarten teacher. I knew nothing—that much I had learned these last few months. [But] her belief was a gift.

MISS SAMSON: Hon, me too.

I was now a teacher on a mission; I was going to show her the sea turtles, something miraculous and new. I thought, I should not be taking her on a field trip at 6:30, I should call her aunt and tell her where we were, and I felt a flutter of panic that I had not just driven her home. I was about to call her aunt and tell her not to worry. [But] I thought, I am a part of this, I am a part of Keisha's life— My hands trembled on the steering wheel; I didn't want to be wrong or unreasonable, but I wanted her to see the sea turtle.

The sea turtle hospital was a single room that held about ten enormous bathtubs. There was a chart marked

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PATIENTS on the wall. It featured a list of unlikely turtle names, such as BING, MAXINE, and HUGH.

There was Bing, who had a hook stuck in his ear, [and] Maxine, who had run into a fishing boat and seemed perpetually shocked as she floated in her tub, staring at us with her unblinking black eyes.

EMPLOYEE: Our goal is to release them back to the sea. It's the greatest feeling . . . When you know it's where it needs to be, when it pushes the water with its flippers…

Keisha gazed at Melissa with interest. It was as though the girl was trying to interpret what the woman was really saying about the world.

KEISHA: Can I touch?

She walked us to the largest tank, where a turtle swam around. He kept bumping into the sides, turning, swimming and bumping again.

EMPLOYEE: *(looking as though she were about to cry)* Hugh's in good health, but he's blind. He was caught in a fishing net and a fisherman banged him on the head so hard he can't see. Turtles can live over a

hundred years. his is where he needs to live for his whole life.

KEISHA: This wasn't in my book. Save him. He needs a better tub! A bigger one. So he doesn't bump his head! *(begins to cry, she kicks the ground hard)*

MISS SAMSON: *(in a firm teacher's voice she takes Keisha's hand and leads here away)* Let's go.

She broke away from me and ran out the door into the parking lot. Keisha ran from the sea turtle hospital, and she could have kept going, through the parking lot, my god, onto the road, but she didn't; she stopped. When I reached her, she was crying, breathing hard.

I knelt in front of her and grabbed her hands. This was not what I wanted to happen, not the happy, triumphant girl I had imagined bringing to her front door; I had wanted her to have seen something good.

MISS SAMSON: *(softly)* It's okay . . . It's okay—

KEISHA: *(taking a large gulp of air as her sobs subside)*

Tell me . . . Tell me what kind of tub he should get.

[And so] I told her . . . big, a mile long, with slides in places to make it fun. It would have special pools with

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rocks. Maybe there could be other nice turtles in there that would be his friends.

KEISHA: Maybe a smart doctor might invent special drops that could cure his blindness and then Hugh could paddle out to sea.

MISS SAMSON: Maybe we would all gather at the shore and watch him swim out, with his perfect new vision. He will remember how to swim, and he will float into the blue, deep water.

KEISHA: Floating . . . He would like that.

She nodded. The sky above us was so dark and seemed weighted, as though holding back something invisible and enormous. I knelt in the crumbling asphalt while her small hands gripped mine and I waited for her.

And then she got back into the car and I drove her home. It was 7:50 p.m. when I pulled to the curb of Keisha's apartment. Keisha waited for me to come around the car and grabbed my hand, and we started walking toward Apartment 3A. *(Long pause)*

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